

Chapter Two

Under the Rain

Nora did not understand the body she was in.

That was the first terror.

Not the rain. Not the street. Not even the reflection of Maya Santos staring back from the dark shop window.

It was the body.

The wrongness of being alive in a shape that was not hers.

Maya's breath came sharp and uneven. Nora felt it in a chest that rose too quickly, felt the ache in a throat that had been holding back sobs for too long. Her hands were cold around the phone. Her left shoe rubbed painfully against the back of her heel. A strand of wet hair clung to her cheek, and Nora wanted to brush it away, but the hand did not move when she commanded it.

She was not controlling Maya.

She was trapped inside her.

A passenger.

Maya kept walking.

The rain had softened the city into blurred gold and silver. Streetlights trembled in puddles. A bus hissed at the curb, its doors opening with a tired sigh. People passed beneath umbrellas, faces lowered, each of them sealed inside their own private weather.

Nora tried again to speak.

Maya's lips remained closed.

Panic spread through Nora, but it had nowhere to go. No muscles answered her. No voice belonged to her. She could only feel.

And there was so much feeling.

It came from Maya in waves.

Fear first.

Then guilt.

Then something Nora could not name, something dense and old that pressed behind Maya's ribs like a hand.

Maya stopped beneath the awning of a closed pharmacy and looked down at her phone.

The screen was cracked across one corner. Nora had never noticed that before.

A message thread was open.

Adam.

Nora's fear sharpened so quickly it almost became pain.

The last message was from Maya.

Thank you for not telling her yet.

Nora stared at the words through Maya's eyes.

Not telling her what?

Maya's thumb hovered over the keyboard. The nail was chipped, painted a dark red that had begun to peel. She typed three words, deleted them, typed again.

I can't keep—

She deleted that too.

A car swept past, throwing water against the curb. Maya flinched. Her hand tightened around the phone.

Then another message appeared.

Adam: Maya, you need to tell Nora soon.

Nora's thoughts scattered.

Tell me what?

The panic changed shape. It became suspicion before she could stop it. Hot, immediate, humiliating suspicion.

Maya pressed the phone to her chest and closed her eyes.

A memory rose.

Not Nora's.

It did not arrive like a normal thought. It flashed through Maya's body with smell and sound attached: hospital disinfectant, a vending machine humming, Adam's voice low and careful.

"She deserves to know."

Maya's voice, breaking. "Not yet."

Then the memory snapped away.

Nora was back under the pharmacy awning, inside Maya's trembling body.

No.

No, that was impossible.

Adam and Maya.

Maya and Adam.

The names sat beside each other in Nora's mind and changed color.

Maya wiped at her face with the heel of her hand. She was still crying, quietly now. Her shoulders shook once, then steadied, as if she had practiced making grief smaller.

Nora wanted to reach for her.

Even inside the fear, even inside the suspicion, that instinct remained. Maya was crying. Maya was hurting. Nora wanted to hold her.

But another part of her was looking at the message.

Thank you for not telling her yet.

The words repeated until they lost grammar and became a wound.

Maya opened the thread again.

This time Nora saw earlier messages, though the screen blurred from rain and tears.

Maya: I don't want her to look at me differently.

Adam: She loves you.

Maya: That's why it will hurt more.

Adam: Secrets hurt more.

Maya locked the phone.

For a moment she simply stood there beneath the awning, breathing through her mouth, trying not to fall apart in public. Nora felt every attempt at control. Every swallowed sob. Every sharp little command Maya gave herself.

Enough.

Walk.

Get home.

Do not call Nora.

Do not ruin her night.

The last thought was so clear, so completely Maya, that Nora almost forgot to be afraid.

Do not ruin her night.

Then the world lurched.

The sidewalk stretched away, impossibly long. The rain stopped falling downward and seemed to hang in the air, every drop suspended like glass. A high ringing filled Nora's skull.

Maya's hand lifted to her temple.

No, Nora thought.

Or Maya thought.

Or both of them did.

The street folded.

Nora hit the kitchen floor with a sound that knocked the air out of her lungs.

Her own lungs.

Her own body.

“Nora!”

Adam was beside her instantly, barefoot, hair damp from the shower, his T-shirt clinging at the collar. He dropped to his knees and touched her shoulder, then stopped, as if afraid to move her the wrong way.

“Nora, look at me.”

She stared at him.

His face was full of fear.

Real fear.

Not guilt. Not secrecy. Fear.

“What happened?” he asked. “You just collapsed.”

Nora tried to sit up too quickly. The room tilted. Adam caught her by the arms.

“Slowly,” he said. “Please.”

She pulled away before she meant to.

His hands fell back.

The hurt passed over his face so quickly that she might have missed it if she had not been staring for signs.

Signs.

That was what everything had become already.

A sign. A clue. A crack.

“I’m fine,” she said.

Her voice sounded wrong after the silence inside Maya. Too loud.
Too much hers.

“You are not fine. You were unconscious.”

“For how long?”

“I don’t know. Maybe thirty seconds.” His eyes searched her face.
“Maybe less.”

Thirty seconds.

But it had felt like minutes. Long enough to stand in the rain. Long enough to read messages. Long enough to become afraid of the two people she loved most.

Adam reached for his phone. “I’m calling emergency services.”

“No.” Nora grabbed his wrist.

He froze.

Her hand was tight around him. Too tight.

“Nora.”

“No doctors.”

“You fainted.”

“I said no.”

The force in her voice startled them both.

Adam studied her, his expression shifting from fear to confusion.
“Okay,” he said carefully. “No doctors right now. But you need to tell me what happened.”

What happened?

She had been inside Maya.

She had felt Maya's tears from behind Maya's eyes. She had seen Adam's name glowing on Maya's phone. She had read words that now crawled beneath her skin.

Thank you for not telling her yet.

Nora swallowed.

"Did Maya text you?" she asked.

Adam blinked. "What?"

"Tonight. Did she text you?"

A pause.

It was small. Almost nothing.

But Nora saw it.

Adam lowered his phone. "Why are you asking that?"

The kitchen became very still.

"Did she?"

"Yes," he said.

Nora's heart dropped.

"What did she say?"

Adam exhaled slowly. "Nora, you just fainted. This is not—"

"What did she say?"

His brows drew together. Not anger. Concern. But concern could hide things. Concern could be a door closing gently in your face.

"She said she got home," Adam answered. "She said she was tired."

Nora waited.

“That’s all?”

Another pause.

“Nora.”

“That’s all?”

Adam looked away.

The movement was tiny.

It was enough.

She pushed herself to her feet. Adam stood too, hands lifted slightly, not touching her this time.

“Why are you lying to me?” she asked.

The words came out before she knew she had decided to say them.

Adam stared at her. “I am not lying.”

“I saw—”

She stopped.

His face changed.

“Saw what?”

Nora’s mouth went dry.

There was no possible sentence that would not make her sound insane.

I saw her messages because I was inside her body.

I felt her crying in the rain.

I heard a memory where you told her I deserved to know.

Instead she said nothing.

Adam stepped closer, cautious. “Nora, you’re scaring me.”

That should have softened her.

It almost did.

But suspicion had already entered the room. It stood between them, patient and breathing.

Her phone buzzed on the counter.

Both of them looked.

Maya.

The name lit up the screen with unbearable innocence.

Nora picked it up.

A new message.

You awake?

Then another.

Sorry. I know Adam is there. Just wanted to say I love you again.
Weird night.

Nora stared at the words.

Weird night.

Her fingers trembled.

Adam watched her. “Is she okay?”

The question struck Nora harder than it should have.

Is she okay?

Not what did she say?

Not why is she texting?

Is she okay?

Maybe it was love. Maybe it was concern.

Maybe it was practice.

Nora locked the phone without answering.

“I need to sleep,” she said.

Adam looked as if he wanted to argue. Then he nodded.

“Okay. I’ll stay on the couch.”

“No.” She could not look at him. “Go home.”

Silence.

“Nora.”

“Please.”

That word did what anger had not.

It moved him.

Adam gathered his coat slowly. At the door, he turned back.

“I don’t know what just happened,” he said. “But I love you. And whatever you think you saw, whatever you think is wrong, talk to me before you decide I’m guilty of something.”

The sentence should have comforted her.

Instead it terrified her.

Because he had used the word guilty.

After he left, Nora stood alone in the apartment they had filled with warmth only hours before.

The rain continued against the windows.

Her phone buzzed again.

Maya.

Nora did not open it.

She sat on the kitchen floor where she had fallen, knees pulled to her chest, and tried to separate what she knew from what she feared.

She knew Maya had cried.

She knew Adam had texted her.

She knew they were hiding something.

Everything else was interpretation.

But fear did not care about the difference.

Fear had already begun arranging the pieces into a shape.

And once Nora saw the shape, she could not unsee it.